



Focused transformation: At the start of the 2026 season, Ancy lost eight kilos, dropping from 63kg to 55kg, while her body-fat percentage fell from 26 to 13. BISWARANJAN ROUT

was already an Asian Games silver medallist at Hangzhou — there was a time when she felt she was living in the shadow of other athletes.

One of them was compatriot Shaili Singh, herself a junior world silver medallist who was considered the heir apparent to Anju Bobby George. Anju herself thought as much. After Shaili jumped 6.76m to move to second on the Indian all-time list, Anju told *Sportstar* she expected Shaili to break her national record one day.

Ancy admits she noticed this.

"I know a lot of the attention was on other jumpers. At that time, it felt a little strange. I was wondering what I needed to do to make people notice me as well."

Few can doubt Ancy's willingness to back up her self-belief. For all the attention she pays to her

appearance, there is little frivolity in the way she approaches her sport.

In 2025, Ancy was diagnosed with PCOS, a hormonal condition that caused her to gain weight rapidly. The extra kilos weighed her down and her form dipped unexpectedly. After tests finally identified the cause, Ancy underwent an intense training and diet regimen to get into the shape she wanted.

"I love rice and *biryani*, but I completely cut everything like that out of my diet. I knew that if I wanted to be a world-class jumper, I had to make sacrifices."

At the start of the 2026 season, the change has been dramatic. Ancy lost eight kilos, dropping from 63kg to 55kg, while her body-fat percentage has fallen from 26 to 13.

As she got into the best shape of her career, Ancy soared, capping it with the stunning performance in Bhubaneswar.

"I wanted to make a statement. This is a record; now they have to consider me too. I am also special. Before, there were people saying, 'She's showing off so much and she's

only the third-best Indian jumper.' But now I'm the best. So what are you going to say now?"

The reaction to her jump was overwhelming.

"I saw that my coach was happy. People were blowing whistles. When I looked at my phone, there were so many messages — be it on *WhatsApp* or *Instagram*. Everywhere I looked, I could see my photo."

But what stayed with her was not the attention itself.

"The thing I felt was that the national record is in my name. 6.88m! It's such a big number."

Bigger dreams

The number is big enough to raise the question of whether Ancy has peaked too early, at a domestic meet rather than an international competition. Those who know her say that is unlikely.

"I've seen Ancy for a long time. She's someone who doesn't change her intensity. She's the same everywhere. She could jump a national record in a district meet or at the World Championships. If she's feeling good, she's going to jump big," says State-mate and one of India's top men's long jumpers Murali Sreeshankar.

What better place to make another big jump than Nagoya? And while India will be hoping for her to win gold, Ancy is already thinking beyond it.

"I'm looking at the Asian Games not just as a competition in itself, but because the qualification period for the next World Championships will begin after that. I need to repeat my jump over there. The qualification standard for that competition is 6.86m. I want to do these kinds of jumps.

"Because I've passed 6.88m, it won't feel like something difficult to do at the Asian Games either. I've already done it, so I'm confident."

Her confidence is not confined to Asia. The 6.88m has taken her into the world's top 10.

"There was a time when I was 80th in the world. But I'm also getting confident that I can compete with them and show that India's not